

Chicago Tribune



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THURSDAY, OCTOBER 16, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Students wait ahead of a news conference by Congress' leaders Wednesday outside the U.S. Capitol. **J. SCOTT APPLEWHITE/AP**

Judge halts the firing of federal workers

Trump seeking more labor force cuts amid government closure

By Janie Har
Associated Press

SAN FRANCISCO — A federal judge on Wednesday temporarily blocked President Donald Trump's administration from firing workers during the government shutdown, saying the cuts appeared to be politically motivated and were being carried out without much thought.

U.S. District Judge Susan Illston in San Francisco repeatedly pressed the assistant U.S. attorney to explain the administration's rationale for the more than 4,100 layoff notices that started going out Friday even though furloughed workers cannot access their work emails and there are no human resources specialists to assist with next steps.

"It's very much ready, fire, aim on most of these programs, and it has a human cost," she said. "It's a human cost that cannot be tolerated."

She granted a temporary restraining order blocking the job cuts, saying she believed the evidence would ultimately show the cuts were illegal and in excess of authority.

Asked for comment, the White House referred The Associated Press to the Office of Management and Budget. The budget office did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The American Federation of Government Employees and other federal labor unions had asked Illston to block the administration from issuing new layoff notices and implementing those that were already sent out. The unions said the firings were an abuse of power designed to punish workers and pressure Congress.

"The president seems to think his government shutdown is distracting people from the harmful and lawlessness actions of his administration, but the American people are holding him accountable, including in the courts," said Skye Perryman, president and CEO of legal organization Democracy Forward. "Our civil servants do the work of the people, and playing games with their livelihoods is cruel and unlawful and

Turn to Shutdown, Page 9

Order forbids warrantless arrests near courthouses

Chief judge enacts rule after groups say presence of immigration agents a cause for alarm

By Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

In the wake of pressure from officials as well as legal and advocacy groups, Chief Judge Timothy Evans has enacted a general order prohibiting warrantless arrests by immigration agents in or around county courthouses.

Earlier this month, Cook County Public Defender Sharone Mitchell Jr. and a coalition of legal groups and social service organizations petitioned the chief judge to take steps to prevent immigration arrests around the court-

houses. The presence of agents around court buildings — including the domestic violence-focused courthouse — has been a cause for alarm for lawyers and community members who feared that people would increasingly not be able to access justice and due process in Cook County.

Court facilities have historically been spared when it comes to immigration enforcement in order to create conditions in which defendants and witnesses are likely to show up for appearances.

Though officials acknowl-

edged that it may be hard to enforce the order, especially for arrests that happen outside the courthouse walls, they argued that it would establish rules and offer guidance to county workers.

The order, which goes into effect Wednesday, says that any person attending court as a witness, potential witness or party to the proceedings shall not be subject to civil arrest absent a judicial warrant while in a courthouse or its environs. The order defines "environs" as public entryways, sidewalks, driveways and parking lots.

The order cites as its legal authority common law privilege that protects people's right to "fulfill legal duties without risking further legal jeopardy."

"We are gratified that the chief judge has exercised his authority to protect our communities, which have been under constant attack by ICE and other federal agents. This is a necessary and overdue action to ensure that the people of Cook County can access the courts without fear," said said Alexa Van Brunt, direc-

Turn to Order, Page 4



Stacy McCloud serves food and beverages to ride-share drivers in the TNP Alpha Lot just east of O'Hare International Airport on Wednesday. She was on duty last week when federal agents raided the parking lot, detaining dozens of people. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Agents descend on O'Hare lot

Witness to immigration raid said 'they didn't focus on anybody who didn't look Mexican'

By Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

In a parking lot just outside O'Hare International Airport Monday afternoon, a man prayed next to his car as a plane took off.

The parking lot, just east of the airport's Terminal 5, is where Uber and Lyft drivers wait for the ride-share apps to assign them passengers. There, the drivers make phone calls and eat lunch. Sometimes, they pray.

Last Friday, Border Patrol officers arrested 18 people at O'Hare,

the Department of Homeland Security confirmed. Labor groups said immigration officers targeted the ride-share drivers' parking lot.

Stacy McCloud, who works at a food truck in the lot, told the Tribune she saw it all.

Immigration agents came to the parking lot twice Friday, once in the morning and once in the afternoon, McCloud said Monday. They surrounded the lot and blocked off its entrance, she said.

When drivers realized that

immigration officials were there, McCloud said, people started screaming "ICE, ICE" and "the whole parking lot just ran."

"People were bumping into each other with their cars," she said. But they had nowhere to go.

Federal agents asked drivers to provide their documents, McCloud said. "They didn't focus on anybody who didn't look Mexican," she said. "Anybody who was Mexican, it looked like they went straight for."

For two years, McCloud has worked at a food truck in the

lot. On Monday, she spoke to the Tribune in between customers, who bought tacos and energy drinks. She had time to talk because business was slower than usual.

Ricardo Velasquez, a ride-share driver eating lunch on the trunk of his car that afternoon, said he is a U.S. citizen, but his friends who aren't were avoiding the airport.

"I feel sorry for all my friends," Velasquez said. "Everybody has

Turn to O'Hare, Page 4

Johnson rejects IG recommendation he fire top adviser



Jason Lee at Soldier Field on April 24, 2024, as the Bears announce plans to build a new domed lakefront stadium. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

By Gregory Royal Pratt
Chicago Tribune

Chicago Inspector General Deborah Witzburg has recommended a top adviser to Mayor Brandon Johnson be fired and placed on a do not hire list for failing to cooperate with an investigation into City Hall's handling of a negotiation with an alderman.

Johnson declined to fire the senior adviser, Jason Lee, and denied that he failed to cooperate with the investigation.

The back and forth was revealed in a summary report released Wednesday by the city's top watchdog. Lee is not named by the inspector general's office, which is generally prohibited from identifying officials by

name, but he called the Tribune to defend his handling of the case.

Witzburg's report stems from fall 2023 encounters between Lee and Ald. Bill Conway. At the time, Johnson was pushing an increased real estate transfer tax on properties over \$1 million to help fund citywide homeless services and an end to the tipped wage for restaurant workers. Conway was looking to have an encampment near Union and Ogilvie stations removed, which he said was a trouble spot for drugs and violent crime in the ward.

As part of his efforts to get the tents removed, Conway spoke with Lee in early October 2023

Turn to Adviser, Page 5



EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE

'We didn't reach all of our goals'

Cubs team President Jed Hoyer reflects on the season, four days after the team's loss to the Brewers in the NLDS. **Chicago Sports**

Internal violence breaks out in Gaza

Analysts say Hamas appears to be trying to assert it is still a dominant force in Gaza. **Nation & World**

